

Figure 1. Former haveli of Bharatendu Harishchandra

Of the millions who visit Varanasi each year, most are pilgrims. Some hope to die here in old age, or at least to be cremated beside the Ganga. This is said to be a sure-shot path to moksha—liberation from the endless cycle of rebirth—for all people, including rogues. Many find this idea silly, as did the fifteenth-century poet-saint Kabir. To illustrate its folly, in his last days, Kabir left Varanasi to die in a town called Maghar, about which it was said, ‘He who dies in Maghar is reborn as an ass.’ Though claimed by sections of both Muslims and Hindus as one of their own, the still-beloved Kabir is of course famous for ridiculing ‘with equal vehemence the sacred books of the Muslims and Hindus, the Muslim mullas and the Hindu brahmins, the Muslim Mecca and the Hindu Kashi’.[6] A free spirit, he fought dogma and oppression in all religions with a gentle and ironic wit. One of his typical short verses goes:

> Saints, I see the world is mad.
> If I tell the truth they rush to beat me,
> if I lie they trust me.[7]